Comparing and contrasting

Goal: To compare and contrast two education systems using comparatives, superlatives and linking words of similarity and difference.

The idea in two lines: Comparing means showing similarities; contrasting means showing differences. We use adjective forms (*-er, more, the most*) and connectors such as *like, both, whereas, while, unlike*.

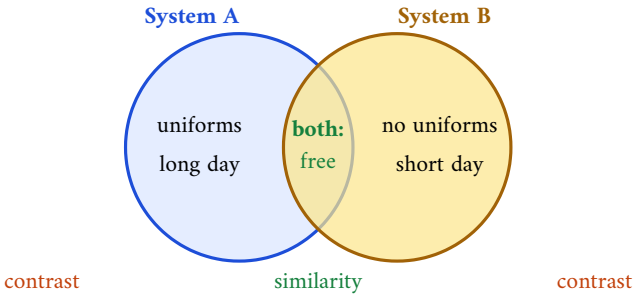


Figure 1: A Venn diagram: differences on the sides, similarities in the overlap.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Comparative:** short adjectives adj + -er + than (*cheaper than*); long adjectives more / less + adj + than.
2. **Superlative:** the + adj-est or the most / least + adj.
3. **Equality:** as + adj + as; inequality: not as / so + adj + as.
4. **Irregular forms:** good → better → the best; bad → worse → the worst; far → farther / further → the farthest / furthest.
5. **Similarity:** *like, alike, similarly, likewise, both … and, the same as.*
6. **Contrast:** *unlike, whereas, while, but, however, on the other hand, in contrast.*

🟢 Examples

1. Combine with *whereas*: *Pupils in System A wear uniforms. Pupils in System B don't.* **Solution:** Pupils in System A wear uniforms, **whereas** those in System B don't.

2. Rewrite: *Private schools are more expensive than state schools.* **Solution:** State schools are **not as expensive as** private schools.
3. Combine with *both*: *Algeria offers free education. Finland offers free education.* **Solution: Both** Algeria **and** Finland offer free education. **Explanation:** plural verb after *both … and*.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Double comparatives: *more cheaper*; write *cheaper*.
- Writing *then* instead of *than*.
- Using *however* without punctuation inside one sentence; it needs a semicolon or a new sentence.
- Confusing *unlike* (+ noun) with *whereas* (+ clause).

🟡 Quick review

- -er / more … than; the -est / the most.
- as … as = equal; not as … as = less.
- Similarity: like, both, similarly.
- Contrast: whereas, while, unlike, however.

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